Gun Culture

Guns in America



A gun show in Houston, Texas. Photo: glasgows (Flickr), CC BY 2.0

Gun Culture

Warm-up: how many are there?

- In groups: I'll show you some things that exist in the US
- How many of each are there?
- Write down your guess before each answer

McDonald's

How many McDonald's restaurants are there in the US?

Write down your guess!

Source: McDonald's, *Restaurants by Market* (2025).

McDonald's

How many McDonald's restaurants are there in the US?

about 13,700

at the end of 2025

Source: McDonald's, *Restaurants by Market* (2025).

Alcohol

How many bottles of wine's worth of alcohol does the average American drink per year?

Write down your guess!

Sources: NIAAA, Surveillance Report #122 (2025); OECD, *Health at a Glance* (2025). One bottle = 0.75 l of wine at 12.5%.

Alcohol

How many bottles of wine's worth of alcohol does the average American drink per year?

about 100 bottles

9.4 liters of pure alcohol, or about 530 drinks, per person aged 14+ (2023)

Austria: about 11.3 liters per person (15+), so roughly 120 bottles

Sources: NIAAA, Surveillance Report #122 (2025); OECD, *Health at a Glance* (2025). One bottle = 0.75 l of wine at 12.5%.

Dogs

How many pet dogs are there in the US?

Write down your guess!

Source: American Veterinary Medical Association, pet ownership survey (2024).

Dogs

How many pet dogs are there in the US?

about 90 million

in 2024

Source: American Veterinary Medical Association, pet ownership survey (2024).

Cars

How many registered vehicles are there in the US?

Write down your guess!

Source: Federal Highway Administration, *Highway Statistics* 2024.

Cars

How many registered vehicles are there in the US?

about 298 million

cars, trucks, buses and motorcycles, 2024

Source: Federal Highway Administration, *Highway Statistics* 2024.

People

How many people live in the US?

Write down your guess!

Source: US Census Bureau population estimate.

People

How many people live in the US?

about 340 million

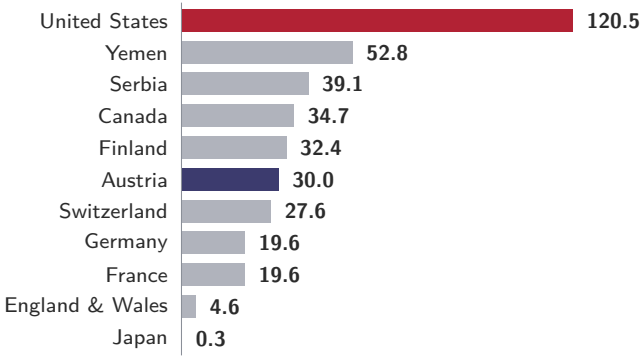
Source: US Census Bureau population estimate.

Now guess: guns

How many civilian guns are there
for every 100 people in the US?

Each group: write down one number

Civilian guns per 100 people



- The US has more guns than people
- Americans are about 4% of the world's population...
- ...but own nearly half of its civilian guns (393 of 857 million)

Source: Small Arms Survey, *Estimating Global Civilian-Held Firearms Numbers* (2018), data for 2017.

Basic Info

How many guns?

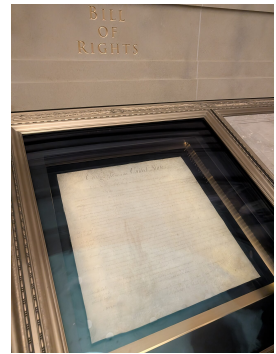
- About 393 million civilian guns in 2017
- Industry-based estimates today: 500 million or more
- More guns than people, but ownership is concentrated:
  - **32%** of adults personally own a gun
  - About **4 in 10** live in a household with one
  - Main reason owners give: **protection**

Sources: Small Arms Survey (2018); Pew Research Center, survey of June 2023.

The Second Amendment (1791)

> *"A well regulated Militia, being necessary to the security of a free State, the right of the people to keep and bear Arms, shall not be infringed."*

- What does it protect? A militia's right, or an individual's right?
- The Supreme Court:
  - *Heller* (2008): an individual right to keep a handgun at home
  - *Bruen* (2022): a right to carry a gun in public; gun laws must fit America's "historical tradition"



The Bill of Rights, National Archives.
Photo: Runner1928, CC BY-SA 4.0

What's legal, what's not?

- **Legal nationwide:** handguns, hunting rifles, shotguns, and (in most states) semi-automatic rifles such as the AR-15
- **Nearly impossible:** new fully automatic machine guns. Only those registered before 1986 can be sold to civilians
- **Banned in some states:** "assault weapons" and high-capacity magazines (about 10 states + DC, including New York and California)
- **Recently loosened:** the federal tax on silencers and short-barreled rifles dropped to $0 in January 2026

Who can buy a gun?

- Licensed dealers must run a federal background check, which usually takes minutes
- Banned buyers include people convicted of felonies or domestic violence, and people committed to a mental institution
- **Private sales** between individuals: no check needed under federal law; about 20 states require one
- Age: **18** for rifles and shotguns; **21** for handguns from a dealer (some states set 21 for everything)
- **No federal gun registry** and no federal waiting period

Let's try a background check!

Answer **yes** or **no**. Simplified from ATF Form 4473, which every buyer at a gun store fills out.

1. Are you buying this gun *for yourself*, not for someone else?
2. Are you charged with a felony right now?
3. Have you ever been convicted of a felony?
4. Are you running from the police?
5. Do you use marijuana or other illegal drugs?
6. Has a court ever found you mentally incompetent, or committed you to a mental institution?
7. Is there a restraining order against you?
8. Have you been convicted of domestic violence?
9. Were you dishonorably discharged from the military?
10. Are you in the US illegally?

Yes to question 1 and no to everything else? Then the store calls the FBI...

The FBI's answer

Proceed
You can buy the gun
(the vast majority of checks)

Delay
The FBI needs more time
after 3 business days, the store may sell anyway

Deny
You can't buy the gun

- Buyers under 21 get an extra check of juvenile records (since 2022)
- Lying on the form is a federal crime
- Marijuana: still on the form, but the Supreme Court limited this ban in June 2026 (*US v. Hemani*)

Sources: FBI, NICS; ATF Form 4473; Bipartisan Safer Communities Act (2022).

Carrying a gun in public

- 29 states: “permitless” or “constitutional” carry, so no license is needed
- Other states require a permit, sometimes with training
- Most states also allow **open carry** (visible, e.g. on the hip)

Source: count as of 2026 (Wikipedia, “Constitutional carry”).

Shooting ranges

- Roughly 8,000+ shooting ranges in the US, indoor and outdoor
- You can usually **rent a gun** at the range, often without owning one or having a license
- Popular with tourists: Las Vegas ranges advertise machine-gun “experiences”

Source: IBISWorld (2025): 8,289 shooting-range businesses.

Compare: the USA and Austria

	USA	Austria
Guns per 100 people	120.5	30.0
Minimum age, handgun	21 (from a dealer)	25 (since 2026)
Minimum age, rifle	18	21 (since 2026)
Psychological test	No	Yes
Waiting period	None federally	4 weeks for a first gun
Carrying in public	No permit needed in 29 states	*Waffenpass*: only with a proven need, rarely granted

Sources: Small Arms Survey (2018); Waffengesetz-Novelle 2025, fully in force since 28 April 2026.

A Polarized Country

Key idea

The U.S. is almost always a country of two minds.

Two Americas



NRA Annual Meeting, Indianapolis, 2019. Photo: The White House, public domain

Watch: "NRA Conference"
Channel 5 with Andrew Callaghan



March for Our Lives, Washington, DC, 2018. Photo: Lorie Shaull, CC BY-SA 2.0

Watch: "Thousands March to End Gun Violence"
The New York Times

My experience

- I don't know a single person who currently owns a gun
- I know only one person (my father) who has ever fired one
- At my university, guns were strictly forbidden on campus
  - One student was passionate about gun rights, and she was seen as a loser / very weird 🤓
- But at the University of Utah (and other schools), students with a permit can legally carry a concealed gun on campus



Park Building, University of Utah. Photo: University of Utah, CC BY 3.0. Emoji: Google Noto, Apache 2.0

Guns follow party lines

45%

of Republicans own a gun

20%

of Democrats own a gun

- Teachers carrying guns at school: **74%** of Republicans in favor vs. **27%** of Democrats
- In the Senate, Democrats almost always get an "F" from the NRA, Republicans an "A"
- Last major federal gun law (2022): **all 50** Democratic senators voted yes, but only **15 of 50** Republicans

Sources: Pew Research Center, survey of June 2023; US Senate vote of 23 June 2022.

New York City: legal, but...

- In NYC, concealed carry is legal with a license
  - i.e. you may carry a gun in public, hidden from view
  - Easier to get since *Bruen* (2022) struck down New York's old "proper cause" rule
- But the culture strongly tilts against it:
  - I've never seen anyone except a police officer carry a gun in the city
  - If I did, I would panic and probably assume the person was crazy
  - Carrying is banned on the **subway**, in **Times Square**, and in many other "sensitive places"



Times Square. Photo: Kritzolina, CC BY-SA 4.0

Big cities vs. everywhere else

- My impression: it's similar in other big cities
- But guns are easy to get almost everywhere:
  - In most states, an 18-year-old can legally buy a rifle or shotgun
  - Handguns from a dealer: usually 21

Read aloud

The New York Times, "American High School Students Are Selling Guns Bound for Cartels," 3 October 2026

> *"They are too young to buy a beer and barely old enough to drive, yet these four teenage boys have already found their way into the criminal underworld."*
>
> *"On weekends, they drive into the Sonoran Desert outside Phoenix. I watched them line up AR-15s and AK-style rifles against their cars, pose for photos and spend the afternoon shooting targets. At night, they head to parties, smoke pot and scroll endlessly through their social media feeds."*

Read aloud (continued)

The New York Times, 3 October 2026

> *"These teenagers are part of a growing network of American high school students and young adults who are helping to arm some of Mexico's most powerful and violent cartels, according to U.S. officials and trafficking experts who are tracking the trend. They source weapons like handguns and high-caliber rifles, and sell them almost exclusively to cartel operatives based in the United States, the teenagers said."*

Read the full article (nytimes.com)

School Shootings

How frequent are they?

- **2026 so far:** 27 school shootings where someone was hurt or killed
  as of 19 October: 17 killed, 29 injured
- Counting *any* gunfire on K-12 and college campuses: 52+
  as of 15 October
- Most school years since 2021 have had **100+** incidents of gunfire on school grounds
- The numbers depend on how you count!

Sources: Education Week school shooting tracker; CNN; Everytown for Gun Safety (144 incidents in 2023–24).

Think

How likely is it that an American student
is shot at school, compared with other dangers?

Putting it in perspective

Deaths per year in the US



Of all gun deaths: 62% suicides, 35% homicides.

- For any one student, being shot at school is extremely rare (about 50 million public school students)
- But guns are the leading cause of death for American children and teens (ages 1–19), ahead of car crashes, since 2020

Sources: CDC final 2024 data (via Pew Research Center, 2026); NHTSA; Education Week; CDC WONDER.

What are we doing about it? (1) Trying to understand it

Possible explanations people offer:

- Violent video games
- Social media
- Family dysfunction
- Easy access to firearms
- Mental illness

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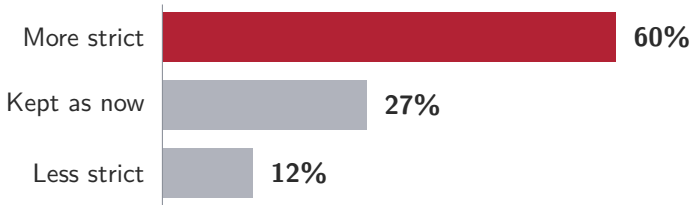
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- Violent video games
- Social media
- Family dysfunction
- Easy access to firearms
- Mental illness

Which of these do you think Americans argue about most? Why?

What are we doing about it? (2) Arguing about solutions

Should laws on gun sales be. . . (Gallup, October 2025)



- **Almost everyone agrees** on stopping people with mental illness from buying guns: **88%** of Republicans, **89%** of Democrats
- **Strong disagreement** on banning assault-style weapons: **85%** of Democrats in favor; a **majority** of Republicans opposed

Sources: Gallup (October 2025); Pew Research Center, survey of June 2023.

What are we doing about it? (3) Politicians

- **2022:** Bipartisan Safer Communities Act, the first major federal gun law in about 30 years (after the Uvalde school shooting)
  - Tougher background checks for buyers under 21; money for "red flag" laws and school mental health
- **2025–26:** the Trump administration has loosened federal rules
  - $0 tax on silencers; rollback of Biden-era rules on gun-show and private sales
  - **Supporters:** restoring Second Amendment rights. **Critics:** making guns easier to misuse
- **States** are moving in opposite directions: more permitless carry in red states, more restrictions in blue states

How do we think of school shootings?

Lockdown drills

- Most American students practice lockdown drills: lights off, door locked, hide silently
- In 2021–22, about **96%** of public schools drilled students on lockdown procedures
- Did you ever have drills like this?

Source: National Center for Education Statistics, Fast Facts.

Final Activity

Discuss at your tables

What might some of the challenges be in restricting access to guns in the US?

Discuss at your tables

What might some of the challenges be in restricting access to guns in the US?

Think about: the Second Amendment ▪ 400+ million guns already out there ▪ politics ▪ culture

You're in Congress

Imagine you are a member of Congress.

Come up with a piece of legislation to address gun violence in the U.S.

- What does it do?
- Who would support it? Who would oppose it?
- Could it pass?